56. Ibid.: 215.

57. Falk (2006): 13–54.

58. This is the reason why all the finer points pertaining to the sources which have been explored and analysed in hundreds of scholarly articles and books are not discussed in exacting detail. Where they figure, I have tried to write about such points in a way that will be intelligible to the general reader.

Notes to Chapter 1: An Apocryphal Early Life

1. The *Harshacarita* of Bana (IV.142) describes the birth of Harsha thus: ‘At length in the month of Jyaistha, on the twelfth day of the dark fortnight, the Pleiads being in the ascendant, just after the twilight came, when the young night had begun to climb, a sudden cry of women arose in the harem. Hurriedly, issuing forth, Suyatra, daughter of Yasovati’s nurse and herself dearly beloved, fell at the king’s feet, crying, “Good news! your majesty, you are blessed with the birth of a second son.”’ Cowell and Thomas (1968): 109. Also see Devahuti (1970): 65.

2. Beveridge (1902): vol. I, 43.

3. Kosmin 2014: 57.

4. For a detailed and learned exposition of the date of Ashoka, see Eggermont (1956). This examines all sources which preserved the chronicle of Ashoka and arrives at the date, mentioned here, by comparing the data of his inscriptions with those that can be gleaned from the literary traditions.

5. For systems of dating used in the inscriptions of ancient India, see Salomon (1998): 172–6. For the chronology of Ashoka, Eggermont (1956). The chronology of the Maurya dynasty has been variously worked out and is usually based on a combination of the Buddhist sources and Puranic evidence. The dates can still differ depending on the aspect of a particular tradition relied upon. Compare Thapar (1961): 14–16 with, for instance, Mookerji (1957): 9–10.

6. Saha (1953): 4.

7. For regnal and other ‘dates’ in ancient Indian inscriptions, Salomon (1998): 170–98.

8. Sarnath stone inscription of Kumaragupta II, verse 1. Chhabra and Gai (1981): 179, 321–2.

9. The historian Beni Madhab Barua had this to say about his reticence: ‘Nothing is more striking and more disappointing to the students of Asoka’s inscriptions than that nowhere in them he has